

WEEK 7 · DEPENDENCY

CLASS 1

Who Cares for Whom?

READING 1

“Chapter 1: Youth as Agents, Caregivers, and Migrants” and excerpt
from “Chapter 6: Debt and Indebtedness” in *Migranthood* – Heidbrink

Migranthood: Youth in a New Era of Deportation | Heidbrink

Week 7, Class 1

Chapter 1: Youth as Agents, Caregivers, and Migrants — pp. 30–51

Chapter 6: Debt and Indebtedness — pp. 158–166

Heidbrink, Lauren. 2020. "Chapter 1: Youth as Agents, Caregivers, and Migrants." and "Chapter 6: Debt and Indebtedness (pp. 158–166 only)." In *Migranthood: Youth in a New Era of Deportation*. Stanford University Press. pp. 30–51; 158–166.

CONTEXT FOR READING

Here's what you need to know before this reading begins...

This reading collects two selections from Migrantism. The first is Chapter 1, “Youth as Agents, Caregivers, and Migrants” (pp. 30–51), in full: the chapter in which Heidbrink reframes Indigenous Guatemalan youth migration as a “cultural elaboration of care” and shows young people already providing for and caring across their households and borders. The second is a coda drawn from Chapter 6, “Debt and Indebtedness” (pp. 158–166), which holds the warmth of that interdependence against its cost: debt as a form of relationality that binds youth to kin, and that can also turn lethal. The book's printed page numbers are preserved throughout; a note like this one marks the omitted material between the two selections.

CHAPTER I

YOUTH AS AGENTS,
CAREGIVERS, AND
MIGRANTS

DOMINGO SQUINTED at the menu hanging overhead, debating between the *tacos de carnitas* and the *torta de longaniza*. “It’s a tough decision,” I echoed. We stepped to the counter for lunch at a taquería in La Villita on Chicago’s southwest side—“*Seis tacos de carnitas, por favor*,” I ordered for us. Seeking reprieve from the scorching August heat, we found a table near the solitary oscillating fan. We sipped *aguas de Jamaica* (hibiscus water) as we processed our recent meeting with a paralegal from a legal aid organization who we hoped would represent Domingo at his upcoming removal proceedings. I met Domingo’s older sister in 2013 in an SBS facility when she was deported from Mexico to San Marcos, Guatemala. A year later, she sent a WhatsApp message asking me to help her fourteen-year-old brother who was recently released from an Office of Refugee Resettlement (ORR) facility for unaccompanied minors in Texas. Domingo arrived in Chicago where he was living with a distant family friend, Rosalía, who had agreed to sponsor him from detention. With limited support to enroll in school or to secure legal representation, Domingo was struggling. Rosalía, a single mother of three children, worked full time at a gas station. She could not afford to take the time off from work to find Domingo an attorney, even less so to pay the \$5,000 fee. Domingo

explained, “I don’t want to be a burden. I do what I can. She’s helping me with a place to sleep and gives me a little money.” In turn, Domingo helped out around the house, cleaned, took Rosalía’s kids to one of the few public parks in La Villita, and remained at home with them so she could pick up overnight shifts at a nearby diner.

Earlier, the paralegal Liz had invited us to sit at an oval table in a cramped conference room. We carefully maneuvered between an oversized cardboard box exploding with Styrofoam cups and paper plates and a half-dozen black plastic bags filled with secondhand clothes waiting to be sorted. As we sat down in two mismatched rolling chairs, Liz turned to a clean page on her yellow steno pad. A multipage intake questionnaire lay on the table, but she never turned the pages. Liz had it memorized. In what amounted to a forty-five minute interview, she asked a litany of questions in Spanish to assess Domingo’s options to remain lawfully in the United States, stopping to rephrase questions only when it was clear that Domingo, as a nonnative Spanish speaker, did not understand. She began:

PARALEGAL: In Guatemala, did the gangs harass, target, threaten, or assault you?

DOMINGO: They make everyone pay a tax. They harassed me every so often, but they didn’t beat me up, if that’s what you mean, no.

P: Were you ever harassed, targeted, threatened, or assaulted because you are Maya Mam?

D: All the time.

P: By whom?

D: Store owners, teachers, police, the government . . . you name it.

P: Do you have a religion? And, were you able to practice your religion freely in Guatemala?

D: Evangelical. I went to a church nearby my house.

P: Have you ever been physically hurt or hit by your parents?

D: My parents? They hit me when I did something wrong.

P: Has anyone ever physically abused you?

D: No.

P: Has anyone ever sexually abused you?

D: No.

P: Since arriving in the U.S., have you ever been forced to work without pay?

D: No.

P: Since arriving in the U.S., have you ever been forced to have sexual contact with anyone against your will?

D: No.

P: Have you been victim of a crime here in the United States?

D: I was robbed last month. They took some money and my bus pass.

Taking a breath of resignation, Liz concluded by asking, “So tell me one more time, in your own words, why did you migrate to the United States?” Domingo replied unequivocally, “To help my family . . . to better our circumstances.”

“She’s not going to take my case, is she?” Domingo later asked me, as he slurped the last drops of his juice. “Isn’t what I suffered enough? She didn’t ask me about the trip. I mean, I experienced some bad things, but that’s not enough, is it? It’s not enough that I’m a good person, trying to help my family and make something of myself.” Indeed, the supervising attorney whom I have known for over a decade called me the next week declining to represent Domingo. She explained, “Most Guatemalan kids come here for economic reasons. They come because they want to earn better wages and seek a better life. Very few come for school or even out of fear from the gangs. There may be a few cases a year of abuse or neglect, but largely they come because mom and dad can’t provide the life they want or because they want to get ahead.”

Domingo’s encounters with immigration attorneys are not unique. Under immigration law, there are few avenues through which economic migrants might remain lawfully in the United States beyond obtaining a specialty work visa typically reserved for high-skilled workers. That Domingo regularly was taxed by local gangs for safe passage to and from school or that he systematically was discriminated against for being Maya Mam was insufficient grounds to remain in the United States. To qualify for asylum, he had to be targeted on account of his race, religion, nationality, membership of a particular social group, or political opinion. Alternatively, he could be eligible for specialized visas as a victim of trafficking, of crime in the United States, or of abuse, abandonment, or neglect. Domingo’s experiences did not fit easily into these narrow categories. Instead, he and most Indigenous Guatemalans, even children, are perceived as individual economic actors in pursuit of personal financial gain and material self-interests.

What the forty-five minute interview failed to grasp, and what immigration law is ineffectual in reflecting, are the complex and historical meanings that underlie seemingly innocuous phrases like “to help my family” and “to better our circumstances.” In contrast to juridical categories and popular discourses of migranthood, Indigenous youth like Domingo have long enlisted migration—internal, seasonal, regional, and increasingly transnational—as a form of intergenerational caregiving. Young people enlist their paid labor, unpaid care work, and mobility to ensure the survival of their multigenerational households amid marginality and precarity in Guatemala. As this chapter argues, migranthood is at once relational and contextual, developing as a social value and economic necessity among Maya families in Guatemala. Put another way, youth mobility is a *cultural elaboration of care*, one rooted in long-standing displacements of Indigenous communities by colonial authorities, dictatorship, genocide, and foreign intervention that continue to destabilize the region.

“*Está listo su orden*” (Your order is ready), the woman yelled from behind the counter. We were no longer hungry.

MIGRATION AS CARE

In contexts of globalization, migration and care are intimately linked. Feminist scholar Rhacel Salazar Parreñas examines the transnational transfer of caregiving and reproductive labor by women in the Philippines who travel to serve as caregivers for children and the elderly in the global North.¹ She details how Filipina migrants leave their children in the care of poorer women in the Philippines, who in turn entrust their children to the progressively lower-waged or unpaid care of family members. Parreñas argues that there is an “international division of reproductive labor” in which poorer women in the Philippines provide reproductive labor to “wealthier women in receiving nations.”² Sociologist Arlie Hochschild synthesized this growing phenomenon of women migrating transnationally to perform care and socially reproductive labor with the concept of “global care chains.”³ Scholars have continued to refine this concept through analyses of how these migration dynamics are additionally racialized, gendered, and classed.⁴ Others have identified how the physical absence of wives and mothers, in turn, shapes the reproductive labor of men and challenges traditional notions of masculinity and the performance of fatherhood.⁵ Across these varied contexts, the concept of global care chains productively

underscores the interconnected social and transnational kinship networks in which migrants and their labor are embedded.

Primarily focused on women and only recently on men, however, this literature predominantly depicts children as either left behind in the global South or as privileged beneficiaries of caregiving in the global North.⁶ In part, this stems both from failing to fully recognize children as social actors and from the increasing transnational relationships among families across borders. This chapter examines how young people like Domingo are also agents of transnational caregiving as their paid labor and unpaid care work circulate through geographic and virtual spaces and across generations. From very young ages, Indigenous children in Guatemala are contributors to household economies by such means as domestic labor, childcare, work in family businesses, and piecemeal tasks such as sewing or bundling spices, often with minimal financial compensation, if any. Even children as young as six or seven years old contribute to family farms or businesses and participate in seasonal migration to the Pacific coast and southern Mexico as well as rural-to-urban migration. Across generations, these experiences develop young people's knowledge, cultivate their work ethic, and hone specialized skills that become essential upon entering the paid labor force as teenagers. To understand the contemporary movements of Indigenous youth and social constructions of migranhood, we must situate their mobility within a genealogy of forced displacement and oppression from colonialism, plantation labor, foreign intervention, and armed conflict to the present-day erosion of collective and familial subsistence farming.

"Social agency" is a social-scientific term referring to the actions and choices individuals make consciously and subconsciously. Agency is shaped by upbringing, cultural beliefs and norms, and social status, among other factors.⁷ For many Indigenous youths, their early experiences establish cultural norms and social expectations of obligation and belonging within expansive kinship networks, expectations that span generations and geography. Social agency is not exclusively individualized and self-determined but also may assume historical and collective dimensions. The social agency of young people is nestled within interdependent social networks and, in contexts of migration, involves a series of choices made within historical and contemporary constraints. Anthropologist Nicholas Van Hear argues that migration decisions are best conceptualized along an axis of choice in which individuals may

move in multiple directions, with varying degrees of choice and compulsion that, at times, are difficult to disentangle.⁸ In other words, the social agency of migrant youth defies simplified typologies of migration as voluntary (economic) and involuntary (forced).

Seemingly new patterns of migration among Central American children suggest that youth are engaged in familial survival strategies that are increasingly transnational and youth-led. Among Indigenous families, young people enact care and belonging through the decision to migrate, their financial contributions to family, and through their unpaid care work. They shape household bonds and mediate conflict by providing emotional and social support to family members adapting to new cultural, social, and economic contexts.⁹ This does not ignore or negate the poverty, violence or abuse that may spur some young people to migrate; instead, it recognizes that youth as social actors and values the cultural, social, and kinship networks in which they are embedded. Subsequent chapters turn to the complex and multiple geographies of violence and insecurity that underpin migratory decisions. Here, I focus on the meanings young people assign to their physical and social mobility, rather than how those in power assign meaning to it. I seek to move beyond reified tropes of young people as simple victims or migrant typologies (such as refugee, economic migrant, or unaccompanied child) to recognize young people as social agents in their own right and, importantly, to learn what they *do* with their agency.

TODOS SOMOS MIGRANTES: SEASONAL MIGRATION

In the summer of 2013, I visited Don Balam, a former colleague and Maya spiritual guide in Momostenango. As we walked through town from the central plaza to his home on the outskirts, we met Juan Diego and his son Alfredo who were returning home from working in the fields. Juan Diego invited us into his home for *atol de elote*. Sitting on the only available white plastic chairs, Don Balam and I sipped the sweet corn-and-milk drink as Alfredo crouched nearby, drawing circles with a stick in the dirt. “*Todos somos migrantes*” (We are all migrants), he explained. Alfredo had been participating in migration to the Pacific coast since the age of nine. Now, at age seventeen, he expounded, “My father and uncles went with their father when they were little, but they harvested corn back then. It’s just what we do. Now, it’s sugarcane; it’s hard work.

I probably wasn't much help when I was younger, but I tried here and there. I helped clean up after them in the fields and brought them lunch. Now, I am old enough and can keep pace."

Juan Diego explained how he and his brother (Alfredo's uncle) came of age in the 1970s and 1980s harvesting corn on small familial plots and more frequently working on corporate-owned sugar plantations. He described how Maya youth of the highlands often migrate from very early ages along historical seasonal patterns to the Pacific coast of Guatemala to harvest coffee, sugarcane, and corn.¹⁰ These patterns have a violent genealogy. During the Spanish colonial period, Maya people were forcibly relocated to serve as slaves. The colonial authorities compelled Indigenous people to migrate in order to provide a range of compulsory labor, including *servicio personal*, labor provided in the form of a tribute or encomienda for the benefit of Spaniards; *servicio ordinario*, a form of cheap labor; and *congregación*, the forcible resettlement of people to facilitate exploitation of their labor.¹¹ Through forced labor on plantations and extreme violence, the Spanish minority asserted its dominance over Indigenous peoples until independence in 1821, with slavery being abolished two years later in 1823.

Freedom from forced labor for Indigenous people was short lived. The ladino (those with a mix of Spanish and Indigenous heritages) elite took power following the withdrawal of the Spaniards and maintained a monopoly on land rights. They established a system of plantations that benefited from an inexpensive, Indigenous labor force and stripped Indigenous peoples of their land. President Justo Rufino Barrios (1873–1885) created new institutions to monitor land use and implemented a series of land reform programs that required landowners to claim individual legal titles to their land.¹² These bureaucratic reforms were contrary to Maya cultural traditions of communal cultivation and ownership. Juan Diego described how his ancestors had previously farmed communally, and when they failed to secure the newly required individual land titles, the government reclassified their land as "unclaimed" and redistributed the plots primarily to the ladino elite.¹³ Unaware of the land reform program and in the absence of eviction by the government, many Indigenous farmers like Juan Diego's great-grandparents continued to cultivate the land, not recognizing until decades later that they had lost all legal rights to property.

As anthropologist Patricia Foxen describes in her ethnography of K'iche' transnational migration, President Barrios's land reforms sought to stimulate coffee as the leading export, while providing "cheap seasonal agricultural labor on large coastal *haciendas* (estates or plantations). These laws targeted Mayas whose 'duty' it was to work on plantations¹⁴ [and] included the legislation of *mandamiento* [forced labor requiring each Indian community to supply a specified amount of labor each year] and *habilitación* [debt servitude]."¹⁵ During this time, laborers were saddled with substantial financial debts that they passed on to their children. A multigenerational system of debt peonage emerged in which many migrated to the Pacific coast to labor as *colonos* (permanent workers) or as *jornaleros* (day laborers or seasonal workers)—migration patterns still in effect over 140 years later. The labor of *jornaleros* became "the property of coffee, sugar, and cotton *latifundistas* (plantation owners), many of whom rented out to Indians in the highlands in exchange for plantation labor."¹⁶ Barrios's policies not only displaced thousands of Indigenous farmers but also initiated the erosion of the traditional system of communal land ownership honored by Indigenous communities at the time.

By the early twentieth century, enterprising German immigrants and *ladinos* began to capitalize on the land seizures of the 1870s. Once again, newly established coffee plantations benefited from the inexpensive manual labor of Indigenous peoples who had previously occupied and cultivated the land. While Indigenous Guatemalans like Juan Diego's family had worked as seasonal migrants along the Pacific coast since the nineteenth century, the 1950s saw increased regional migration of Guatemalan laborers into Mexico as the consolidation of large tracts of land into the hands of the elite limited the capacity for survival of Indigenous communities in rural Guatemala.¹⁷ By 1979, over two-thirds of Guatemala's population resided in rural areas, yet approximately 54 percent of land plots were too small to support subsistence farming.¹⁸ This trend has only continued.

Now, as Alfredo astutely identified and Juan Diego historicized, there have been notable shifts in Guatemalan agriculture. Since the early 2000s, major land rushes among sugarcane and African palm producers increasingly have driven subsistence corn farmers out of work in an attempt to satiate U.S. and European demands for biofuel. Some small farmers have sold their land due to failed crops and the associated financial debt (see chapter six); others

are coerced into selling their land when neighboring plantations cut off their water supply or when access to public roads becomes deliberately restricted. Juan Diego clarified, “The buses stop, so there is no way to get to the land. *La renta* [charged to the bus drivers] gets too high.” Here, Juan Diego references *la renta*, a daily fee imposed by gangs, narcotraffickers, and private security of multinational corporations on bus drivers to ensure safe passage. These concurrent strategies choke off access to land and coerce landowners to sell their properties, most commonly for mining speculation. “Others are threatened or beaten,” Alfredo chimed in.

There are few protections for small landowners and even fewer for laborers like Alfredo and Juan Diego against harassment and coercion by elite landowners and multinational corporations. In response to a public call for protections of the lands of small farmers, a 2013 rural development law sought to promote enhanced access to land, employment, and labor protections. However, it was met with fierce opposition by large landholders and private businesses and quickly was rejected by the Guatemalan congress. Without state intervention or legal protections, wage-labor migration continues unabated. Indeed, the seasonal migration has become more of an individual or family strategy rather than a collective enterprise as in previous generations.¹⁹ As a family strategy, young people—girls and boys—participate through their labor in the fields or through their everyday activities of shopping, cooking, and cleaning, as Alfredo described of his childhood.

HEMOS HECHO DESDE SIEMPRE:

REGIONAL MIGRATION

Plantations in southern Mexico likewise rely upon the labor of Indigenous Guatemalans. Ignacio, sixteen years old and recently deported from Mexico, explained that his family began working seasonally in Chiapas, Mexico: “In Mexico, it costs more to get there, but the wages are better, and we make a bit more in the exchange rate from pesos to quetzales.” At nine years old, Ignacio began accompanying his uncles and cousins to southern Mexico. Massaging his palm with his thumb, he described his first trip to Mexico:

At first, it was an adventure, a way to escape school. I remember sleeping on the floor at the camp and tending the chickens with another boy, Manuel. We

fed them every morning and cleaned up the living barracks—washed, swept, made beds. Occasionally, a man would tell us to sort seeds. We were paid by the number of kilos we could sort. I remember my fingers hurt, but I didn't stop because I wanted to contribute. They bled and cramped up at first. They hurt for days. Still do, but I got used to it. Manuel and I would race to see who could sort the most; we made a game of it, so we wouldn't be so bored. Now [at age sixteen], my fingers are too fat, so I pick grapes.

Youth as young as six or seven years old describe migrating to labor camps principally in Chiapas, Oaxaca, and Veracruz in southern Mexico. Initially, children may accompany their parents, extended family, or fellow community members as helpers on coffee plantations. The labor of children in particular is enlisted in tasks requiring fine motor skills, such as picking coffee, cleaning crops, and classifying and packing exotic plants.²⁰ National statistics indicate that approximately 13 percent of migration to Mexico is attributed to youth aged fifteen to eighteen years old; because official statistics do not count children under fourteen years old, the data likely underestimate the scale of child labor migration.²¹ For Ignacio, migration to Mexico was a means by which he and his family responded to their immediate needs, while minimizing the assumption of large debts and avoiding the risks associated with migration to more distant locations.

Young people describe learning the bus routes and safe crossing points over time, and developing relationships with foremen who might later hire them. Upon reaching sixteen years old, Guatemalan youth legally can travel alone with documentation indicating parental permission to work. Frequently, however, these documents are neither provided nor requested. Many youths say they continue to migrate, joining siblings, cousins, and peers, in order to support their families and to plan for their own marriages, parenthood, and households. For those like Ignacio willing to brave the increasingly dangerous journey further north, grape harvesting in central Mexico promises better wages and relatively less taxing physical labor. Regional migrants may confront the cartels and gangs that troll migratory routes and charge a tax for passage and may likewise encounter enhanced immigration enforcement in Mexico. In 2016, immigration officers detained Ignacio and his uncle at Siglo XXI, Mexico's largest detention facility located in Tapachula, Chiapas. Initially surprised,

Ignacio later reflected, “*Hemos hecho desde siempre. ¿Por qué estoy aquí?*” (We have always done this. Why am I here [being detained]?) He described how he was detained alongside several farmers with muddied sandals and machetes who immigration authorities apprehended as they worked their own lands along the Guatemala-Mexico border.

UN EQUILIBRIO: INTERNAL MIGRATION

Indigenous youth sequentially or concurrently may participate in other contemporary patterns of rural-to-urban migration. As poverty deepens in the highlands, Indigenous youth may travel to Guatemala City temporarily, semipermanently, or permanently to participate in the growing private security industry, serving as guards for private homes and businesses of the elite. Young people also labor in the informal sector, shining shoes, washing and guarding cars, and/or selling wares on the roadside or *chicle* (gum) in the marketplace. I encountered a few very young children (ages six to nine), mostly boys, who made the trip to Guatemala City alone; more frequently, thirteen- to seventeen-year-olds travel by themselves and negotiate labor agreements as *ayudantes* (assistants) in small shops or on buses. When physically capable, boys participate in the construction industry in Guatemala City, which offers higher wages but few labor protections. Girls also migrate to Guatemala City, at times to work as waitresses or assistants in restaurants and shops, provide childcare, or more commonly, serve as domestic laborers or caregivers for the elderly in middle-class households.

When she was thirteen years old, Maria Clara traveled to Guatemala City from the K’akchiquel community of San Marcos La Laguna in the department of Sololá. She recalled, “My mother didn’t support me leaving but I think my father understood why I left.” She sipped her hot chocolate as I tried to catch a glimpse of my children who were climbing in an indoor play place at a café in Guatemala City where we were meeting. Maria Clara, now seventeen years old, explained her reasons for moving to Guatemala City. “I wanted to have my own money and to be more independent. I didn’t want to stay in San Marcos [La Laguna] for the rest of my life; I wanted to see something and to help my family.” Her older brother also left the family home in 2012 without his parents’ blessings, migrating to the United States where I would eventually meet him at a facility for unaccompanied minors in Chicago. The small envelope with \$300 and two photographs that I was hand delivering to Maria Clara from her

brother was testament to this aspiration. Maria Clara laughed as she thumbed through the photographs of her brother, hair slicked back, standing next to a yellow corvette with black racing stripes. Another photograph showed her brother with the nighttime lights of the Chicago skyline illuminated behind him. “He’s seeing something for sure. I can’t imagine,” she chuckled.

Maria Clara described that her cousin had secured her a position as a domestic worker in the middle-class home of an engineer and his family in Guatemala City’s Zona 12, where she cleaned, cooked, and tended to their three children six days per week. “It’s not so bad. It could be worse like the girls who get trapped into selling themselves in [Mexico’s southern city of] Tapachula. At least my *patrona* [employer] is not cruel and I get one day off to myself.” In Guatemala, there are no standard legal protections providing for minimum wage nor for an eight-hour work day. In spite of her sixteen-hour days and minimal pay, Maria Clara felt fortunate as the labor conditions of other Indigenous youth who migrate to Guatemala City are often far more abusive and exploitative.

“I try to establish *un equilibrio* [a balance],” she explained regarding her efforts to send money home to her parents and still afford an occasional luxury item, such as floral soaps and lotions, a new blouse, earrings, or magazines. At first glance, it would appear that Maria Clara is attempting to juggle the economic needs of and social obligations to her family with her own desire to enjoy material goods that are often restricted to the middle and upper classes, but this *equilibrio* defies neoliberal understandings of migranthood as simple economic migration. Here, Maria Clara is invoking the K’akchiquel concept of balance. As anthropologist Edward Fischer explains, contrary to notions of balance as a seesaw in which quantities (goods, time, and the like) are distributed in oppositional relation to a center point, balance is understood as centeredness.²² That is, feeling grounded physically and metaphysically or in harmony between humans and the cosmos. For Maria Clara, the meaning she assigns to her obligations are firmly rooted in cultural values and beliefs that intimately bind her to family, community, and indeed the universe.

These multiple and often interrelated migratory trajectories—seasonal, regional, and internal—are not uniquely a contemporary phenomenon nor mutually exclusive. Over time, a culture of migration has developed as a means of survival and as a social value.²³ It is deeply ingrained in Maya youths’ formative experiences. For Alfredo, seasonal migration is “just what we do” because

“todos somos migrantes” (we are all migrants). For Ignacio, regional migration is an activity; *“hemos hecho desde siempre”* (we have always done this). For Maria Clara, family members who migrated to the United States and to Guatemala City facilitated her internal migration and her ongoing contributions to family, while enabling her to nurture a material and cosmic *equilibrio* in her life. Alfredo, Ignacio, and Maria Clara understand their migranhood as interwoven with their personal desires, social obligations, and cultural values, and it enables their contributions through their paid labor and unpaid care work. For others, these contributions take the form of transnational migration.

UN ACTO DE AMOR

As with seasonal, regional, and internal migration, young people’s caregiving roles and social obligations shape the decision to migrate internationally. Some youths migrate seasonally or regionally for years before undertaking more distant transnational migration. For Maribel, transnational migration marked the first time she would leave her village of Ixchiguan in the department of San Marcos. As we strolled through Ixchiguan’s Saturday market, Maribel explained that at the age of thirteen, she volunteered to migrate in support of her family. Her father had died in a bus accident three years prior, and her mother was facing complications from untreated diabetes. With an older brother already living outside of Atlanta, Maribel was the eldest child remaining in Ixchiguan.

She described both her motivations for and apprehensions about migration, explaining, “I know it will be hard, but I must go. I am preparing myself—my body, my mind. We don’t have the conditions for survival here. My family needs me. *Me toca migrar*. [It’s my turn to migrate.]” Maribel and her family were well aware of the dangers of irregular migration—including extreme weather, riding the freight trains through Mexico, gangs, police corruption, and sexual violence. Her younger brother, whom I had met one year prior in an SBS facility for unaccompanied minors deported from Mexico to Xela, had shared the gruesome details with Maribel and me in the family’s courtyard. Yet Maribel’s commitment to her family remained her most salient motivation for migration, a decision that her mother openly grieved but reluctantly supported as the only alternative for familial survival. Maribel’s younger brother, whom I had come to Ixchiguan to visit, had just left for the United States; Maribel hoped to meet him *“al otro lado”* (on the other side).

Maribel's neighbor, fourteen-year-old Bernardo, had also recently left Ixchi-guan. Bernardo's parents initially forbade his migration, citing their reliance on his wages. Sitting at their kitchen table, his father Armando described the deliberations of their son's desire to migrate: "I told [my son] that we didn't have the money to support him going to the United States. He managed to gather together funds from his uncle in Maryland, sold his motorcycle, borrowed from friends—all to pay the coyote. I worry about him. Every day I worry, but I know he is resourceful and hardworking. He will survive." Showing me a picture of his son standing in front of a grocery store in Los Angeles, Armando said, "*Él será alguien. Soy orgulloso. Fíjate, migración es un acto de amor.*" (He will be someone. I am proud. Look, migration is an act of love.)

With his parents' tacit support, Bernardo was able to draw on his peer and familial connections to secure the necessary funding to ensure a modestly safer passage to the United States through the contracting of a *pollero de confianza* (trusted smuggler) well known in Ixchiguan. Without familial support and social capital, Bernardo might not have had the financial resources to undertake irregular migration, yet as a resourceful, hardworking, and determined young man, he gathered piecemeal the necessary funds and incurred considerable financial debt to migrate transnationally. For many, migration bolsters young people's important position within kinship, communal, and ethnic networks—networks that offer emotional and financial support over time and space. Now, as a migrant in the United States, Bernardo is a source of pride for his family. For his father, this migration is the embodiment of Bernardo's love for and commitment to his family.

In my interviews, many young migrants described the conditions prompting migration in terms of high rates of unemployment, scarce arable land, mounting familial debt, limited employment and education opportunities, and family emergencies (such as accidents, illness, and death). Alongside these structural causes, migration mediates and is mediated by social relationships and cultural values. Young people shared their desire to contribute to familial survival and sustenance of future generations. Amid the extreme poverty and structural violence, young people and their families are left with few viable options to meet everyday household needs while remaining in Guatemala. In a cultural context that values and depends upon their contributions to households and communities, Indigenous youth enlist migration—be it seasonal, regional, internal,

or transnational—as a historically rooted strategy to navigate growing poverty and instability in Guatemala.

REMESAS TIENEN ROSTRO . . . TIENEN RACISMO

In contexts of regional and seasonal migration, analyses of household survival—both by families themselves and by researchers—generally ignore young people’s paid and unpaid contributions. Within transnational migration, however, financial contributions in the form of remittances are assigned considerable significance. In traditional development discourse, remittances are generally understood as financial contributions made by adult, economic migrants in the global North to sustain households in the global South. In Guatemala, many actors have a stake in the growing flow of remittances: banks, money transfer companies, states, communities, NGOs, multinational corporations, churches, and beneficiaries themselves, not to mention those engaged in the movement (extrajudicial or state sanctioned) of people and goods across borders. The World Bank reported that \$9.49 billion was remitted in 2018 alone, 12.1 percent of Guatemala’s annual gross domestic product.²⁴ Because of the sizable financial contribution made by the estimated 1.5 million Guatemalans working abroad, migrants are seen as, in the words of former President Óscar Berger, national “heroes and heroines of Guatemala.”²⁵ While institutions such as the World Bank monitor the growth of remittances as an indicator of development, research has found that remittances among Maya families in the highlands of Guatemala have not been a development panacea.²⁶

Discussions of remittances are predicated on a limited understanding of them as exclusively financial transfers of money from adults to families in countries of origin. However, for Indigenous migrant youth in the United States, their economic contributions to the household assume additional layers of meaning. “*Remesas tienen rostro*” (Remittances have a face), explained Carlos. At age fifteen he harvested pecans in Georgia, dividing one-third of his monthly income between his pregnant young wife Jacqueline in Maryland and his family in Cajolá. Carlos and Jacqueline, whom I met in 2012 in an ORR facility for unaccompanied minors outside of El Paso, Texas, had migrated with the hopes of earning money to purchase land in anticipation of starting their own family. Sitting in their family’s courtyard in Cajolá three years later, Carlos’s

mother detailed how she utilized Carlos's monthly remittances. "We pay for food and school fees first. We save a little for land. If there is a little that remains, we buy the children clothes."

Carlos's family relies upon his monthly remittances, albeit modest, for their everyday life and the education of his younger siblings, a contribution that brings Carlos pride. As we drank coffee at a local diner in northern Georgia, Carlos remarked, "It feels good. My family has worked hard. Now, it's my turn." For Carlos, remittances are relational and socially meaningful. Through his transnational migration, he feels better equipped to contribute financially to his family, and as a result, gains personal satisfaction and pride. His remittances have direct material impacts on his family, making possible the investment in a *tortillería* (tortilla shop) and a *tienda* (small store) adjacent to the family home as well as greater social standing from being modestly upwardly mobile. His contributions are not anonymized financial transfers; they are infused with care and commitment to his family. They have a face.

In the wake of the 2016 U.S. presidential election, many families began to brace for mass deportations, a campaign promise of then candidate Donald Trump. With considerable anxiety about the safety of loved ones living undocumented in the United States, families began to make difficult decisions about how to reallocate already limited economic resources. Prior to the elections, Valentina's monthly remittances from Georgia covered her thirteen-year-old daughter Lucía's private school fees in San Marcos. Overtaxed and underfunded, Guatemala's public schools often lack the most basic resources such as textbooks, bathrooms, blackboards, and qualified teachers. As such, families like Lucía's prioritize the use of remittances to enroll their children in a growing number of urban private schools that purport higher quality of instructors and specialized accommodations. Following the election of Donald Trump, however, Valentina's life in Georgia became exceedingly precarious. Fearful of a raid at the meatpacking plant where she worked, according to her daughter Lucía, Valentina stopped going to work. Anxious about encountering openly racist attacks emboldened by Trump's xenophobic rhetoric, she rarely left her apartment to purchase groceries or to attend church. "She was really worried, and we were worried for her," Lucía explained of her mother's situation. Compelled by her newly restricted income, the family made the difficult decision to withdraw Lucía from private school. Valentina's parents with whom Lucía lived in San

Marcos began to send reverse remittances—the equivalent of Lucía’s monthly tuition payments—to Valentina in Georgia to sustain her until, they hoped, the anti-immigrant climate in the United States would lessen.

Given that 16.6 percent of Guatemalans live in the United States, Lucía’s family was not alone. These concerns were widespread. Several families reported sending money, from \$100 to \$500 per month, to the United States when their migrant family members initially arrived and needed financial support to pay for rent, transportation, and food while they sought employment. Lucía’s grandfather shared that, during the 2008 financial crisis, he sent several money transfers of short-term loans to Valentina when she was unemployed, in an effort to delay her premature return to Guatemala. “We had invested so much, and she suffered to get to the other side. I didn’t want her or anyone else to have to take that journey again,” he rationalized. Following the 2016 presidential elections, families described how they sold land, consolidated households, deferred starting new businesses, or chose not to invest in additional harvests, all in an effort to keep income liquid and accessible as they braced for the economic fallout of lost income resulting from the detention and deportation of a loved one. Wary of the heightened anti-immigrant rhetoric of Donald Trump, Lucía’s uncle observed, “*Remesas tienen racismo*” (Remittances have racism).

Lucía told me, “My mom went to the United States for me, to support my education. Although I’m not in school right now, I hope it will pass, and I’ll return next term when she can be safe in Georgia.” Lucía’s emotional support of and her grandparents’ reverse remittances to her mother demonstrate that remittances can be multidirectional, dynamic, and nonmaterial. Particularly in periods of crisis or adversity, regardless of direction, remittances enable the sustenance of transnational households over time.

For Maya youth and their families, remittances are total social events—dynamic, multidirectional, and multilayered—rooted in contemporary phenomena but also in a historical context of loss of land and displacement that has given rise to a culture of migration among young people. Don Balam from Mostotenango shared with me, “With remittances, we can create spaces that have excluded us. We are in a better position to follow our journey, to organize in solidarity with others both here and there [in the United States], and to restore the rightful order of our land.” For Don Balam, remittances are perceived as a vehicle through which communities may right past wrongs and might purchase

and redistribute pilfered land. Thus, remittances link the present to the past but also to the future.²⁷ The varied financial, social, and historical meanings of remittances attest to the need to understand migration and corresponding remittances beyond singularly economic terms. By contextualizing and historicizing migranthood and the social networks that facilitate youth mobility, we begin to understand its meaning for young people and their families.

OVERLOOKED AND UNDERVALUED

In addition to social and financial remittances, Indigenous migrant youth contribute their unpaid care work to the survival of their households. Rather than reinforcing a bright-line distinction between paid labor and unpaid care work, sociologist Nicola Yeates suggests that care “covers a range of activities to promote and maintain the personal health and welfare of people.”²⁸ For Indigenous youth, either in the United States or following their deportation to Guatemala, their care work consists of cooking, cleaning, shopping, childcare, elder care, maintenance, and tending animals. Young people shape household bonds and mediate conflict by providing critical emotional and social support to family members adapting to new cultural, social, and economic contexts.²⁹ Their care work is vital to the maintenance of a household over time and across geopolitical distance.

Ramona, a thirteen-year-old from a Mam community in the department of Quetzaltenango, emigrated to Louisiana, where she cared for her young niece and nephew while her elder sister worked as a waitress and her brother-in-law as a carpenter. Following her deportation to Guatemala, Ramona explained:

My sister and brother-in-law are working hard for us. They are doing their best to support our family and they helped to get me [to the United States]. I just did my part, helping however I could—making tortillas, preparing lunches, washing clothes, watching the kids. They were teaching me English and helped me with my homework when I got frustrated. I really missed my family and friends. I did my best there. It wasn't always easy there, but it isn't easy here in Guatemala either.

Ramona identified her contributions as caring for her niece and nephew as well as supporting the household through everyday domestic chores. While Ramona acknowledged the loneliness and homesickness that accompanied

her migration, she also recognized the benefits of living in a multilingual and supportive household.

At age fifteen, Aura cleaned houses alongside her twenty-five-year-old aunt Hilda in Chicago, together saving money to finance her younger brother's migration in two years' time. As we exited the bus heading to the Museum of Science and Industry on the city's south side, Aura described to me, "Hilda helped me to travel here. She provides me a place to live and found me this work. She is patient and kind. She says she remembers what it was like when she first arrived, and I really see how she cares for my parents by supporting me. I trust that I, too, can contribute to my family and to those that come after me." Consistent with Maya cosmovision that holds that all things and actions transmit positive and negative potential, Aura recognized that her care work maintained the potential to meaningfully impact herself and others. Aura did not view her own actions and interests in a vacuum. Rather, her care work was a form of interlocking responsibility to Hilda, her family, and her community for their financial, emotional, material, and spiritual support.

While care work is often gendered, with girls providing considerable emotional and domestic labor, young boys also are critical caregivers to their families in their home countries and elsewhere. At sixteen years old, Marvin joined his father in Oregon after six years of separation. While his mother Gisela and younger siblings remained in Guatemala, Marvin and his father worked as migrant farmworkers up and down the West Coast, remitting money each month to pay school fees and gradually to build their family home. Gisela described:

I worry about [my husband]—he doesn't tell me what life is like there. He sounds tired and his health is not good. I'm so glad Marvin is with his father, so he can cheer him up when he is missing us. And, Marvin tells me how life over there is. He helps me to know that we will be together again. It is just a matter of a couple of more years apart.

Marvin provided emotional support and feelings of connectedness to his father following a prolonged separation. He also offered assurances to his mother in Guatemala with updates on his father's health, a source of anxiety for Gisela. Through his presence over the past year in Oregon, Marvin facilitated familial sentiments of belonging in multiple sites, despite their geographic separation.

As members of transnational households, many young people maintain their sense of kinship and belonging in spite of geographic distance. Upon arrival in the United States, many young migrants describe remaining intricately connected to communities of origin through phone and WhatsApp calls, text messages, social media, emails, letters, and remittances and by sending such material goods as clothing, shoes, and technology such as radios, tablets, cellular phones, and computers. In addition, young migrants report sending money for special events such as patron saint festivals; ceremonies; holidays; life events such as marriages, births, and deaths; and special fundraising initiatives, such as the construction of a soccer field or playground or specific infrastructure improvements to local parks, roads, or churches. Thus, for most young migrants, physical absence does not signify that they are devalued members of families and communities; rather, they demonstrate their ongoing interconnectedness to familial, cultural, and social networks that facilitate their migration, settlement, and at times, return. Examining the paid and unpaid care work of young people considers both the material and immaterial ways in which they contribute to household well-being over geographic space and the ways families may express their cultural and social valuation of young people's labor, which is "often overlooked and undervalued."³⁰

CARE ACROSS GENERATIONS

In the context of the migration of Indigenous youth, examining migration through the lens of care allows us to consider the material and affective contributions of young people and how the intensity and direction of care and caregiving shift over time. Anthropologist Kristin Yarris explores the ways Nicaraguan grandmothers care for their grandchildren when mothers migrate, tracing how moral and cultural values are brokered and regenerated by grandmothers.³¹ In contrast to migration literature that predominantly focuses on the labor of migrants, Yarris opens up critical avenues to understand how care is embedded in diverse familial, social, political, and often gendered dynamics and how care moves across generations. So, too, Indigenous children in Guatemala circulate care. A young girl may be the recipient of her mother's or grandmother's care, but as she enters early adolescence, her assumption of household responsibility and caregiving grows. The needs of parents and children are under constant negotiation; transnational migration as a rite of passage for many youths de-

marks a pivotal shift in the obligation for and distribution of care across the generations, in which a parent's investment of financial and social capital in their child's migration becomes an investment in the household's future well-being.

Tracing the ways that care circulates in and through households reveals that migranthood is relational. Young people participate in transnational caregiving across borders and generations and, over time, the migration of Indigenous youth has become a cultural elaboration of care. Analyzing the unpaid care work of young people alongside their paid labor signifies that physical absence or separation does not necessarily indicate a lack of emotional connection or belonging between youth and their families; to the contrary, among Indigenous communities, how a family decides who migrates may be an expression of trust, love, and investment rather than of abuse, neglect, or abandonment as is often depicted. By examining young people as recipients of caregiving and as caregivers themselves, and the ways care circulates, we might likewise conceptualize mobility more broadly, including the social and economic mobility that may facilitate or result from migration. In this way, we might learn the multiple and varied ways that children—as people and as socially constructed categories—move across geopolitical borders, through culturally defined stages of life, and across spaces designed to shape their experiences of growing up.

CHAPTER 2

WIDENING THE FRAME

DURING THE SUMMER OF 2014, headlines of every major news outlet covered the seemingly surprising arrival of tens of thousands of young migrants: “Children at the Border” (*New York Times*); “More Youths Crossing U.S.-Mexico Border Alone” (*LA Times*); “Desperation, Hope and Children on the Border” (*CNN*); “Obama Calls Wave of Children Across U.S.-Mexican Border ‘Urgent Humanitarian Situation’” (*Washington Post*). I boarded a plane, returning to Guatemala for a second summer of research at the height of this influx of Central American children arriving unaccompanied in the United States.

As I waited in the customs queue in Mexico City’s international airport, a pseudodocumentary played overhead on a loop on large flat-screen television. Dressed in a red hoodie and faded jeans, a young girl’s shoulders shivered, her head bent. Her face was concealed from the camera’s gaze. She wept as she recounted her rape, which had occurred on a clandestine route along the U.S.-Mexico border. A uniformed Mexican immigration officer sat by her side consoling her. I glanced around in disbelief. The other travelers in line seemed oblivious to the irony that this film, an effort to deter irregular migration, played at an official checkpoint in an international airport to an audience with

CONTEXT FOR READING

Pages 52–157 are omitted from this reading. Here's what you need to know...

You'll resume in Chapter 6, “Debt and Indebtedness.” Chapters 2–5 and the opening of Chapter 6 are omitted. The coda below picks up inside the case of one Almolonga family: Adrián, a father deported from New York; his wife Ixkik, whose untreated illness first drove the family into debt; and their teenage daughter Micaela. You'll join them at the point where the family begins to weigh Micaela's own migration. The selection then continues through two further cases, Eulalia's and Sebastián's. Page numbering resumes at p. 158.

that she may have to migrate, but I do not know what other options we have. My daughter doesn't have anything, and this is my fault. I am the cause of so much suffering that many times I just wish to die so they do not have to care for me."

When asked about the prospect of migration, Micaela responded, "On Mother's Day, my father and I prepared Kaq'-ik [a traditional Maya Q'eqchi' stew] for my grandmother. We asked for her blessings and support. My grandmother is powerful, and I will only go if she supports me and believes that I can contribute. I want to help my family and my mother, but I will go only with her blessings. She says she will consider it." Amid everyday precarity, young people like Micaela are contributors on whom their families rely for moral support, caregiving, and paid and unpaid labor. When I returned to the family home six months later to invite Micaela to a workshop with youth in the community, Adrián shared that she was now cleaning homes in New York and caring for his brother's newborn.

Through the experiences of Adrián, Ixkik, and Micaela, we see how debt is acquired and utilized as well as the intergenerational impacts of debt—directly and indirectly—on the migration of young people. Just as care is familialized—that is, families undertake the responsibility to care for their members in the absence of the state—so, too, is debt. In most instances in Almolonga, assuming financial debt and ensuring repayment are understood as familial and often intergenerational obligations, rather than an individual's responsibility. The absence of health care for Ixkik spurred Adrián's migration and migratory debt; and the (in)ability to repay debt shapes the everyday lives, options, and futures of not only Adrián and Ixkik but also Micaela. In K'iche' culture, *dando mi palabra* (giving my word) is intertwined with one's trustworthiness, dependability, and respect as well as one's family's. In contrast to claims that Almolonga lacks a "repayment culture," the pressures of repayment are weighty and shared by extended, intergenerational kinship networks. For Micaela, this comprised her parents, grandmother, aunts and uncles, and cousins both in Guatemala and in the United States. Taken in context, Micaela's migration is a family affair, one that weaves together a complex web of factors and forces that shape the decision to migrate, the conditions of the journey, as well as social obligations across generations.

UNA GRAN ESTAFA

“Es pura necesidad” (It’s pure necessity), Eulalia explains as the reason for her migration to New Jersey. At seventeen years old, Eulalia followed seasonal migration patterns to the Pacific coast of Guatemala and later to southern Mexico to harvest coffee alongside her father and elder brother. In Almolonga, 10 percent of families migrate seasonally within Guatemala, primarily to the Pacific coast and occasionally to Guatemala City. An additional 8 percent migrate regionally either to southern Mexico to harvest coffee or to El Salvador to labor on export crops. Of the households with seasonal and regional migrants, approximately 18 percent include household members like Eulalia who are under the age of eighteen. These data likely underrepresent national trends of child labor migration, as Almolonga is somewhat unique in that it maintains a strong import-export economy. At the same time, these rates are illustrative of the insufficiencies of the local labor market to garner livable wages for families, necessitating seasonal and regional migration to supplement household incomes. Wage-labor migration persists as a familial survival strategy, primarily for young men and boys who undertake the physically taxing labor.⁸ As a young woman, Eulalia’s participation in this labor migration spoke to her family’s dire straits. In this context, transnational labor migration is one of multiple household survival strategies in which Maya children and youth actively participate by fulfilling social expectations and meeting economic needs.

When her father died in a car accident, the family income unexpectedly plummeted. Eulalia’s family sought a bank loan of 40,000 quetzales (5,260 USD) at 3.5 percent monthly interest to cover funeral expenses *“para cumplir con la costumbre”* (to adhere to custom). Based upon one’s collateral and financial position, the bank’s interest rates can be as low as 3 percent compounded monthly, rates that are considerably lower than those offered by local moneylenders, notaries, or cooperatives. For those with limited collateral, a co-signer or *fianzor* is required. Eulalia and her family enlisted a paternal uncle as a cosigner of their loan. Her uncle Edú, who ran a successful import-export business, maintained a line of credit that facilitated his ready access to funds for unexpected business expenses. Community members with lines of credit shared that this credit was particularly helpful in instances of emergency, such as a funerals, accidents, illness, lost wages, natural disasters, or failed harvests.

Those without established lines of credit and who likewise confront an urgent situation sought funds primarily from lawyers, notaries, and moneylenders, often at much higher interest rates (from 5 to 50 percent monthly) and stricter terms than bank rates and terms, which issue shorter repayment schedules and require greater collateral for lesser-resourced applicants.

Recognizing few options, Eulalia explained, “My aunt in El Norte [the United States] sent some remittances. We begged from neighbors to loan us a few quetzales. We sold our household furniture. My sisters and I sold our *güipiles* [traditional blouses]. We borrowed from the bank. We didn’t bury my father properly; we just couldn’t afford it. We used the money for me to travel *allá* [over there].”

Initially, Eulalia was proud that her family selected her to migrate to the United States. “I’m old enough, work hard, get good grades, and I speak Spanish. They trust me,” she rationalized. Indeed, migration debt is not always negative or exclusively financial. Many youths view migration debt as a form of belonging and of trust, investment, and social obligation that binds them to their families. Indebtedness is a form of relationality, as debt in practice binds migrant youth to a wider community. The social indebtedness that youth experience toward their families bolsters their important positions within expansive kinship, communal, and ethnic networks—networks that offer emotional, spiritual, and financial support. Eulalia identified her migration as a collective investment in her family’s future, a gesture of their trust in her to provide for them. After two deportations from Mexico, Eulalia expressed feelings of failure for not reaching the United States.

Eulalia also recognized that the consequences of debt extend beyond her immediate family to her uncle and his family. If they did not begin payment on the cosigned bank note, Eulalia elaborated, her uncle risked losing agricultural land and the season’s harvest upon it. Hopeless and ashamed, Eulalia conceded that her fifteen-year-old sister, Sofia, might fare better. Perhaps recognizing the perils of multiple migrations as deterrents to young would-be clients, many smugglers now extend their offer of three attempts to a family rather than to a specific family member. Sitting in a courtyard with her sister and me, Sofia recounted: “I begged my mother to let me go. I want to help. I earn 25 quetzales [3.29 USD] a day and work four days a week. We don’t have enough to eat, to pay for medicine. If I don’t go, we will lose our home . . . And, if I die, at least I will die trying to help my family, rather than die here in misery.”

Women and girls in Almolonga must navigate competing discourses on the ease with which they might migrate. Some men dismiss the threats facing women in claiming that women and children migrate more easily through Mexico and into the United States. “*Las mujeres entran fácilmente y los hombres sufren.*” (Women enter easily, and the men suffer.) These dismissals diminish the risks that women and children face in Mexico. Young girls in particular shared that they found it challenging to convince family members to support their migration because the risks were seen as too great or women and girls were considered “too weak” to undertake the journey.

In Almolonga, women and girls readily identified the gendered risks of migration, including sexual violence, pregnancy resulting from rape, and sexually transmitted infections. Eulalia said, “*Lamentosamente, ahora la violación es un costo de migración; los costos de deportación todavía peores.*” (Regretfully, rape is now a cost of migration, but the costs of deportation are still worse.) These additional risks associated with deportation include gendered stigma, rumors of promiscuity, and accusations of adultery—with problematic assumptions that women must sleep with someone “voluntarily” or coercively—in order to arrive in the United States. Accordingly, some young people do not tell their parents of their intentions to migrate for fear that their parents would not support their decision or that it would bring worry and concern. In other instances, families describe concealing their child’s migration, claiming that they were “going on a trip,” “visiting family in Guatemala City,” or “working in the capital” so as to protect them from the social stigma if confronted with deportation. In both instances, family members articulate considerable anxiety about the migration of loved ones.

As with Micaela, the conditions that spurred Eulalia’s migration are at once intergenerational and structural. Eulalia’s seasonal migration alongside her father and brother is a well-worn strategy for many Guatemalans to manage precarity. As discussed in chapter one, historically, Indigenous families were coerced into providing labor on plantations in southern Guatemala. Although forced labor was abolished in 1940, the patterns of labor migration continue unabated. Researchers have documented how the labor of Indigenous workers is preferred due to racialized logics that claim Indigenous people are better suited for the physical demands of labor and that Indigenous people can be compensated less than their ladino counterparts.⁹ In addition, there is a growing number

of young people who are drawn to work in rural *maquilas*, or export apparel assembly factories. Together with the plantations along the Pacific coast, rural *zonas libres* (free trade zones) along the Pan-American Highway offer wage-labor opportunities for young people. These industries reinforce and intensify, rather than alleviate, existing social inequalities and intergenerational tensions while simultaneously instantiating powerlessness among Indigenous communities within the world economic system.¹⁰ To understand the “pure necessity” that Eulalia describes, we must historicize it, linking wage labor and migration as a means of managing everyday structural violence across generations.

Following her father’s death, income from wage labor became insufficient. Eulalia’s family relied on any and all available credit to ensure survival, including the selling of their *traje*, arguably the most prominent visual marker of their Indigenous identity. Amid this intergenerational precarity, families turn to an increasing number of financial institutions and informal actors that are now in the business of loans. While some borrowers in Almolonga invested in their businesses, the returns only mitigated the short-term needs of families rather than providing future financial stability. In very few instances in the survey did families improve their economic situation over the long term. To the contrary, in 28 percent of households that utilized loans, financial interest quickly surpassed the principal, sinking families into financial ruin while financial institutions and actors flourished. For Eulalia and Sofia, it only ensured their survival for a few more months. In spite of banks and cooperatives advertising loans that claim to “*mejorar la calidad de vida*” (improve your quality of life) or “*satisfacer las necesidades de tu hogar*” (satisfy the needs of your home), ready access to credit, even within relatively more regulated financial industries such as banks and cooperatives, reinforces and at times exacerbates inequalities. Displaced and unsettled, Eulalia describes, “Now, my family is like a bird with nowhere to land.”

While social networks in Almolonga have weakened, especially as credit among families is increasingly scarce, they have not entirely eroded. Eulalia’s uncle Edú shared that he had observed the profound and disproportionate impact of loans on the community. Unbeknownst to his niece, he served as a cosigner to seven family members, friends, and neighbors because of their inability to pay interest rates on their loans. In some instances, he paid off the loans, most recently for his cousin who could not make payments on a loan of 45,000

quetzales (5,920 USD) with 18 percent *daily* interest. Another brother-in-law had not paid Edú for four years for the 38,000 quetzales (5,000 USD) Edú paid to Banrural so as to save the family's land from dispossession. Given this added economic hardship on Edú and his family, he explained his motivation:

I hate to see them lose the land where our grandparents' grandparents lived. What will happen to their children if they lose their home? I stepped forward to pay them because I could not do *nothing* while the banks and lawyers and moneylenders take their children's inheritance and take over the town. *Es una gran estafa* [It's a big scam/fraud], not only by the banks but also by the rich and the corrupt in the government.

Edú recognized the injustice of these loans and their intergenerational impacts on Almolonga as a community. He laid blame on the banks, the elite, and corrupt government officials who collude to impoverish Indigenous peoples and dispossess them from their land.

LETHAL DEBTS

When their eldest son Tómas died from untreated diabetes at the age of thirty-four, Fernando and his wife Francesca welcomed Tómas's widow and their five grandchildren into their home. Their seventeen-year-old son Sebastián, with his own newborn on the way, felt compelled to migrate to support his new and growing family. Fernando was initially supportive. "We mortgaged our land and our home to the [cooperative] to support Sebastián. It was a difficult decision. My wife was sick, my knees and back are no good anymore. I cannot work like before. I didn't think we had another choice."

The 60,000 quetzales (7,895 USD) Fernando and Francesca received for the deed of their home would secure Sebastián's three attempts to cross Mexico into the United States, but he would never arrive. "Initially, he was worried but determined," his sister-in-law shared. For Sebastián, his first failed migration and deportation from Mexico to Guatemala signified not only an inability to provide for his family and his newborn son, but also the family's potential default on their loan from a nationally recognized cooperative. With no institutional follow-up or services for young people following deportation to Guatemala, the conditions that spurred Sebastián's migration were compounded by the financial debt his family enlisted for him to migrate irregularly. Rather than return

to Almolonga, Sebastián remained in Malacatán, a Guatemalan municipality along Mexico's southern border, for twenty days before trying again.

Following his second failed attempt and with a quickly mounting debt, Sebastián migrated again almost immediately. "He was frantic. We told him to rest, to prepare himself. The journey requires strength, but he would not listen," Fernando commented. Sebastián's deportations placed considerable financial strain on their family. Unable to meet the interest payments on the loan, the cooperative began foreclosure proceedings on their home. After Sebastián's third failed attempt, the family was evicted from their land.

An attorney told me, "Mortgaging one's land is a civil process in which an individual administratively and free of coercion enters into a legal and financial contract. Because it does not fall in one's favor does not signify a crime has been committed." Rather than criminal or predatory behaviors on the part of moneylenders, notaries, or banks, the attorney points to "misfortune." In so doing, she collapses debt-driven migration into legal and political paradigms that distinguish *economic* or *voluntary* from *forced* migration, rather than recognizing the coercive role debt plays in driving migration.

Ashamed at what he viewed as a personal failure, Sebastián spiraled into depression and alcoholism over the next two years. His father sighed, "We lost our home, our land, our livelihood, and our son. *La deuda lo mató* [The debt killed him]." Sebastián died of alcohol poisoning at the age of twenty.

Now living in a two-room house with a corrugated metal roof, they struggled to survive. Unable to pay the 120 quetzales (16 USD) per month to their neighbor who loaned them electricity, Sebastián's family recently lost power. Still overcome with grief, Francesca mourned, "He went looking for life. He only found death."

In Almolonga, local understandings of migranthood are infused with social, cultural, and religious values and are influenced by kinship relations, economic precarity, and gender norms. For young men like Sebastián, migration is a rite of passage, one intimately rooted in notions of masculinity. In Guatemala, migration is often gendered, whereby young men are propelled by the desire to fulfill social expectations as providers. For some, migration may facilitate their changing social positions as heads of household, property owners, businessmen, and supporters of extended family networks, and even their prospects for courtship. Such were the aspirations of Sebastián who, according to his

mother, wanted “to be someone” and “to have a future.” As adolescents transitioning to adulthood, this rupture relegates youth to a prolonged period of “waithood” or “liminality”—waiting to get married, to have children, and to advance socially and financially.¹¹ Deportation marks the foreclosure of opportunities for upward mobility and serves as an often indefinite postponement of future plans. Moreover, for Indigenous youth, because giving one’s word is intimately connected to identity, trustworthiness, and respect, the failure to repay migratory debts throws youth into profound moral and social turmoil, calling into question not only their trustworthiness and dependability but also that of their families within community life.

Migration and the performance of masculinity it enables, however, cannot be understood exclusively in financial terms. So, too, migration restructures masculinity in the ways it shifts scripts about the emotional lives of men and the meaning of fatherhood. Take, for example, Adrián, who contributes to domestic chores such as cleaning and washing dishes. During special occasions, he and his brothers gather together to cook Kaq’-ik for their mother, joking about how life in the United States forced them to learn new skills. “We either cooked or we starved,” Adrián explained. At a family gathering, his brother who was deported from New York grinned as he took a bite of tamales. “I would trade with Adrián cooking for cleaning. I hated cooking but he’s pretty good, no?” The interactions between Adrián and Micaela likewise reveal a tender and supportive bond as they navigate the emotional toll of Ixkik’s illness and the uncertainty of their shared future.

The emotional ramifications of financial insecurity on the lives of young migrants and their families cannot be discounted. Sebastián’s tragic death and the enduring impacts on his family leaves little closure and no happy ending. For many, migranhood is not simply a romanticized dream deferred or an elusive opportunity foreclosed. For Sebastián and his family; Ana and her son, Pedro; Adrián, Ixkik, and Micaela; and Eulalia and Sofia, it is a matter of life and death.

The ways migrant youth frame migranhood—as a rite of passage, as a fulfillment of gendered norms, as an escape from indebtedness, as a fulfillment of caregiver and care-provider roles, and as a form of familial obligation—exist alongside more disparaging, contradictory accounts of deportees—as scapegoats for crime, alcoholism, and drug use¹² or as cultural contaminants who

pose a risk to the preservation of Indigenous culture and social values—that transform deported youth into a perceived social risk.¹³ At the community level, Sebastián’s depression and alcoholism were viewed as illustrative of the vagaries that deportees bring to the community, including alcohol, drugs, and sexually transmitted infections. “*Él era tal por cual*” (He was a good-for-nothing), a neighbor declared. Held as responsible and culpable for crime, violence, and social vices, community members identified deportees like Sebastián as “bringing problems,” “trashing the town with beer bottles,” “running clandestine bars,” “selling drugs,” “beating their wives,” and generally “going down the wrong path.” Migrants and deportees were also disparaged for their consumerist ways, with a “desire to have riches rather than work hard” as a common refrain. These stereotypes are pervasive in Almolonga even while 13 percent of its households are impacted by forced removal of a household member, either from Mexico (32 percent) or from the United States (68 percent). Data from the department of Quetzaltenango judge who serves in Almolonga, however, do not corroborate assumptions that returned migrants were disproportionately responsible for crime in the community. According to the judge, 47 percent of the complaints presented to the Policía Nacional Civil (National Civil Police) involved violence directed toward women and were not disproportionately representative of deportees. As many Almolonguenses critically contend, while lauded nationally, migration does not bring development; it brings loss and suffering.

Given that the evangelical church maintains considerable power in Almolonga, narratives of migration and deportation also are assigned religious meanings. “If you do not arrive, you do not believe,” declared an evangelical pastor during a Sunday sermon. If deportation is understood as an individual and spiritual failure, and often internalized as such, then the corresponding vices associated with it can only be remedied by conversion and religious practice, as another pastor, Luis Gonzálo, elaborated: “Since Almolonga’s rebirth, we are a community of believers; we no longer drink.” In part because church leaders have declared alcoholism incompatible with evangelism, deportees I met who sought to establish Alcoholics Anonymous in Almolonga described being driven from the community. In this view, conversion to evangelism is cast as the cure for addiction, physical illness, social ills, and consumerist desires. Yet,